



Note 2 burns mid-air

A Samsung Note 2 phone caught fire mid-air on a Singapore-to-Chennai flight. <http://dgit.in/Note2Fire>



Apple & Tuplejump

Apple has now acquired an India/US-based machine learning team, Tuplejump. <http://dgit.in/AplTplJp>

Origins

WORMS ARMAGEDDON

A worm is a computer program whose sole purpose is to replicate and occupy system resources as well as network bandwidth. In 2001, the Code Red worm made headlines by exploiting a flaw in the Microsoft Internet Information Server to spread globally in a few hours. The worm was instructed to replicate itself only for the first 20 days of the month, block web pages on an infected server with the message "Hacked by Chinese" and then, on a certain date, launch a Distributed Denial of Service attack on the White House website.



RECENT THREATS

The kind of viruses that worked earlier don't work nowadays. We've gotten better when it comes to securing our gadgets with tools like antiviruses and firewalls. But malicious code has just shifted its focus towards exploiting flaws in systems and is still causing damage. Take the example of Heartbleed, a vulnerability in the widely used open source cryptographic library Open SSL. It could be used to obtain confidential information by just sending a message of shorter length than declared. Even Android's Stagefright is more of a bug more than a virus, but it has to be triggered by a specific MMS message (that requires no action from the end user) and grants the attacker complete access to the phone, which might include instantly crashing it as well.



FUTURE OF VIRUSES

Malicious code which used to be nothing more than cyber vandalism has now evolved to full fledged cyber crime. And in this connected age, it might be possible to lose access to your devices and information due to the same technology that has enabled their existence. Malware targeting smartphones are emerging now, and soon it will be shifting towards Point of Sale terminals and the Internet of Things. A good example of current capabilities is the Moker remote access trojan. It's hard to find and remove and bypasses almost all known security measures. The only way forward right now is to change faster than the threats are evolving.

